

Week 11: Humour, Satire, and Canadian Identity

This week, we explore how literature uses **humour** to do far more than entertain. Through Thomas King's *"One-Two-Three Little Indians"* and Roch Carrier's *"The Hockey Sweater,"* we examine how laughter can expose prejudice, challenge national myths, and invite readers to question ideas they might otherwise accept without hesitation.

Common Assumption #1

Humour is primarily entertainment — light, amusing, and not intellectually serious.

Common Assumption #2

Canadian literature is polite and avoids difficult subjects like colonialism, race, and identity.

The Reality

Humour is defined by its **purpose** — in literature, laughter lowers our defenses so we can confront uncomfortable truths.

Satire as a Literary Technique

Satire is a literary technique that uses **humour, irony, exaggeration, and absurdity** to criticize people, behaviours, institutions, or social values. Rather than attacking directly, satirical writers invite readers to recognize contradictions for themselves. A reader may laugh at a situation only to realize moments later that the humour reveals something deeply troubling.

Key Principle

Satire does not merely criticize society — it encourages readers to examine their own **participation** within it. Instead of saying "your assumptions are wrong," satire quietly asks: *"Have you ever thought about why you believe that?"* This invitation to self-reflection is often far more persuasive than direct argument.

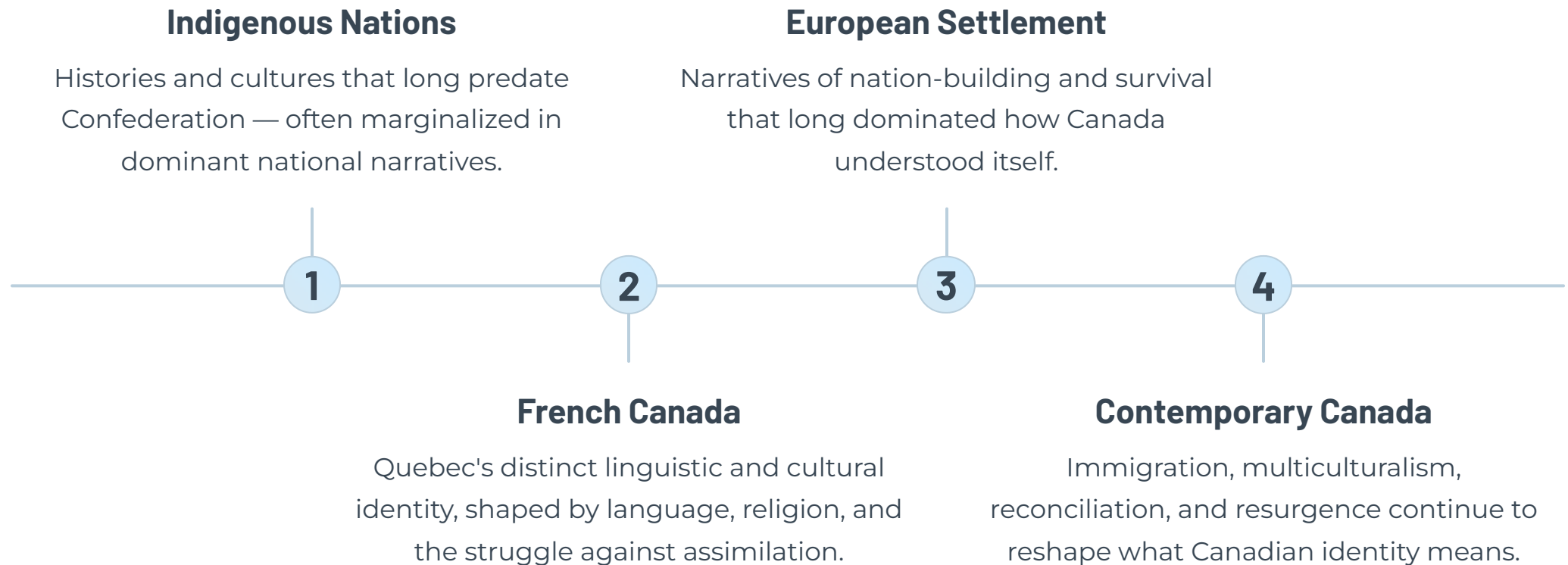
Satire Works Through

- **Humour** — lowers the reader's defenses
- **Irony** — reveals contradiction between appearance and reality
- **Exaggeration** — amplifies social problems for effect
- **Absurdity** — makes familiar assumptions seem strange
- **Self-reflection** — the reader arrives at conclusions themselves

What unites these techniques is not *what* is being criticized, but *how* that criticism reaches the reader.

Canadian Identity: A Nation of Many Voices

Canadian literature has a long tradition of using humour to challenge national myths. Although Canada is often associated with politeness, multiculturalism, and peaceful coexistence, Canadian writers frequently ask difficult questions about colonialism, language, identity, race, and belonging. Consider how the question of Canadian identity has evolved across different voices and traditions.



Canadian identity cannot be reduced to a single story — it is **continuously negotiated** rather than permanently fixed.

This Week's Key Works

Both of this week's readings use humour to explore questions of identity, but they do so in remarkably different ways. Each author draws on specific cultural contexts that shape how their humour functions and what it reveals.



Roch Carrier – "The Hockey Sweater"

Set in rural Quebec during the 1940s, a young boy receives a Toronto Maple Leafs sweater instead of the Montreal Canadiens sweater he desperately wanted. Through childhood innocence, Carrier explores language, cultural belonging, and the tensions between English and French Canada.



Thomas King – "One-Two-Three Little Indians"

King uses satire to expose stereotypes about Indigenous peoples that continue to shape Canadian society. Rather than presenting Indigenous identity as fixed or easily recognizable, he challenges readers to examine the assumptions they themselves bring to the text.



Contemporary Canadian Satire

Programs such as *Little Mosque on the Prairie*, *Kim's Convenience*, and *North of North* all use humour to explore belonging, cultural misunderstanding, and identity — demonstrating that this tradition continues today.

i These works reinforce a key idea: humour creates space for conversations that might otherwise feel **uncomfortable or defensive** — making it one of literature's most powerful critical tools.

The Hockey Sweater – Symbol and Identity

At first glance, Carrier's story appears wonderfully simple. A young boy wants the right hockey sweater. Within the story, however, the sweater becomes something much larger than clothing — a symbol of loyalty, belonging, and community.

Why the Sweater Matters

The young narrator does not simply dislike the Toronto Maple Leafs sweater because of its colour. He experiences it as a threat to his place within the social world he knows. Carrier uses this childhood experience to illustrate how communities establish powerful expectations about belonging. Understanding Maurice Richard's significance within French Canadian culture during the 1940s and 1950s reveals that the sweater symbolizes cultural pride and resistance to assimilation — not merely a sporting preference.

A Defining Shift in Reading

Carrier transforms an ordinary object into a layered symbol:



A Simple Clothing Mistake



A Symbol of Language, Power, and Cultural Identity

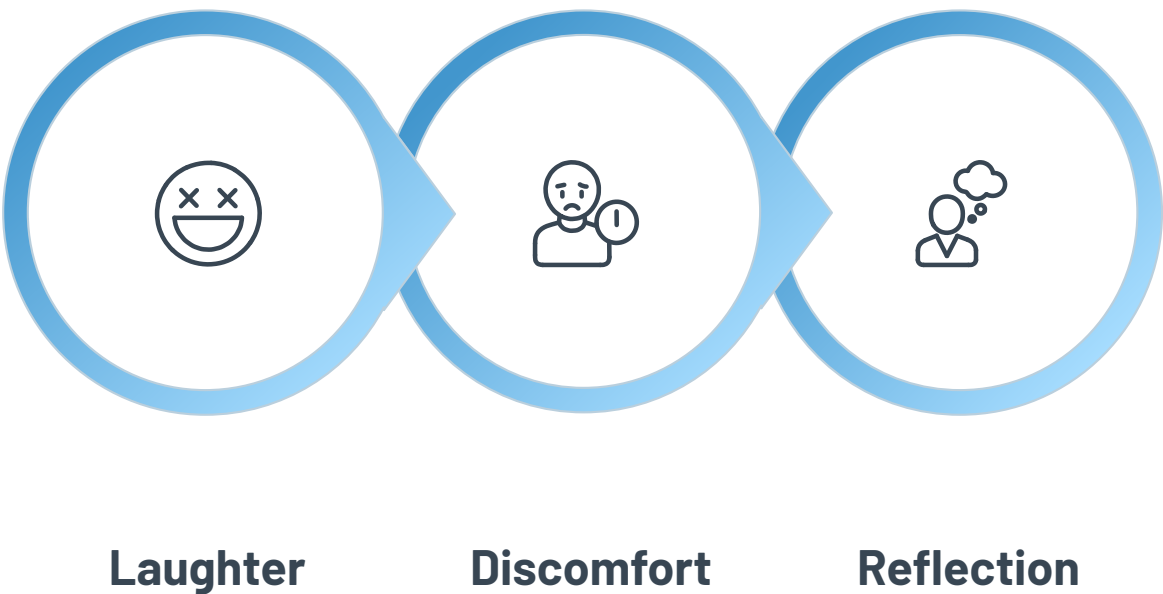
How Humour and Satire Create Meaning

Both Carrier and King demonstrate that questions of identity often appear in surprisingly ordinary moments. Humour creates meaning through three core mechanisms — and reading satire is fundamentally an **active process** of self-reflection.



Consider: A child wears the wrong hockey sweater. We laugh at the exaggerated reaction — until we remember our own experiences of not belonging. The humour works because it connects a **personal emotion** with a **broader social truth**. This understanding is not given directly. It is **constructed by the reader**.

Unlike direct political argument, which can cause audiences to become defensive, satire allows readers to arrive at conclusions themselves. Thomas King's humour often depends upon readers recognizing stereotypes they themselves hold — making the self-reflection both surprising and lasting.



Unlike prose that states its argument directly, satire relies on the reader to bridge the gap between laughter and critical insight — making it a deeply participatory and interpretive act.

Activities, Key Takeaways & Looking Ahead

This week's readings demonstrate that identity is not experienced only through governments or national holidays — it also exists in childhood memories, casual conversations, community rituals, and even the clothes we wear. Before concluding, complete the following activities.

Activity 1 – Canadian Identity Through Different Lenses

- Choose one memorable scene from either reading (250–300 words)
- Explain why it stood out and what it suggests about Canadian identity
- Discuss how humour or satire encourages different thinking about the issue

Activity 2 – Humour as Social Commentary

- Find one contemporary Canadian satirical example (cartoon, clip, or article)
- Post ~300 words analyzing the issue, the humour's effectiveness, and its connection to this week's readings

Key Questions for This Week

- **What does it really mean to be Canadian?** — and who gets to decide?
- How does humour lower our defenses so we can confront uncomfortable truths?
- Can criticism of a nation also be an expression of care for it?
- When we laugh at a story — what is that laughter asking us to see?

Coming Next Week

We will continue examining how literature shapes public conversations, with a focus on the relationship between storytelling, memory, and national identity — and how contemporary writers are expanding what counts as a Canadian story.

References (APA)

Carrier, R. (1979). *The hockey sweater* (S. Fischman, Trans.). Tundra Books.

King, T. (2003). *One-Two-Three Little Indians*. In *A Short History of Indians in Canada*. HarperCollins.

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